

Canvases for Better Thinking

Slowing Down to See the Problem Clearly

Solutions shouldn't be rushed—especially for complex problems. The instinct to jump straight to answers often leads to narrow thinking and missed insights.

The better approach? Step back, structure the problem, and explore it from multiple angles before deciding what to do next.

Overview

One of the most common challenges in workshops is premature convergence—teams move too quickly into solution mode without fully understanding the problem.

Participants naturally default to their own expertise, focusing on familiar lenses such as technology, operations, or customer experience. While valuable, this often results in fragmented or incomplete thinking.

A canvas introduces structure to the conversation, ensuring that problems are explored holistically before solutions are formed.

What is a Canvas?

A canvas is a structured, visual thinking tool—typically a single page divided into sections, each representing a different lens, question, or consideration.

Each section prompts participants to explore the problem from a specific perspective. These might include:

- Customer experience
- Technology feasibility
- Financial implications
- Risk and compliance
- Operational impact

Unlike static frameworks, canvases are highly adaptable. They can be designed and tailored to suit the specific challenge, audience, and outcomes of any workshop.

Why It Works

Broadens perspective by forcing consideration across multiple lenses

Reduces bias by moving beyond individual expertise or functional silos

Creates structured discussion rather than unstructured debate

Builds shared understanding through collaborative exploration

Improves alignment before moving into solutioning

Where unstructured discussion leads to fragmented insights, a canvas creates coherence.

Workshop Example

Challenge: “How might we improve the enterprise customer onboarding experience?”

- Canvas lenses might include:
- Customer pain points and moments that matter
- Internal process inefficiencies
- Technology constraints and enablers
- Cost to serve and financial impact
- Regulatory or compliance considerations

How to Run It

- Define the core challenge with the sponsor
- Identify key lenses relevant to the problem (5–8 is ideal)
- Design the canvas with clear prompts in each section
- Brief participants on how to use it
- Run in breakout groups to complete the canvas
- Share back and synthesise insights across groups

Supporting Thinking

The use of canvases is grounded in structured thinking and design methodologies.

Frameworks like the Business Model Canvas and LUMA concept posters demonstrate how visual structure can simplify complexity and guide better conversations. By externalising thinking into defined sections, teams are able to process complexity more effectively and collaborate more meaningfully.

